Releasing the gatekeeper from duty: the role of social network in victim crime reporting

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Introduction: From *gatekeepers* to *help-seekers*

- Any victimization is known to be unexpected and cause stress and confusion (Janoff-Bulman, 1986).
- A victim of crime is expected to turn to others in order 'to reduce their uncertainty and be reassured' (Ruback et al., 1984).
- I aim to make case for reframing reporting as a social process rather than an individual decision, *à la* Pescosolido (1992).
  - Hence, a victim is redefined: from *gatekeeper* (Gottfredson & Gottfredson, 1987) who's primary function is to trigger the criminal justice system — to *help-seeker* who can take multiple paths in navigating the aftermath of victimization.
- I show that activation of one's social network affects the path one takes in help-seeking: notifying the police becomes much more likely.

Introduction: Missing the social, or the data–theory feedback loop

- While often overlooked, the importance of social network in victim crime reporting is not unrecognized (Bergemann, 2024).
- However, most of the work on the subject was focused on sexualized assault and intimate partner violence (Baert et al., 2024), evidence for other types of crime remaining scarce (Xie & Baumer, 2019).
- As Knoth and Ruback (2019) put it, '*studies that assess differences between individuals who report to the police, seek alternative help, or do nothing [...] often fail to recognize that individuals who do end up calling the police are likely to first seek advice from a third party*'.

Introduction: Missing the social, or the data–theory feedback loop

- Crime victimization surveys were designed to assess the dark figure of crime. They captured:
  - features of an incident,
  - features of a victim,
  - if the crime was reported to the police.
- Early studies found that reporting was strongly associated with *seriousness* of crime and implied *cost–benefit* calculation behind the decision to report (Skogan, 1984).
- They also found only mixed evidence of importance of a victim's *demographics* and *attitudes towards the police* — being counterintuitive, this summoned more research focusing on these features.
- Thus, the quantitative research remained constrained to the original conceptual scope and the *entrepreneur* metaphor.

Introduction: Missing the social, or the data–theory feedback loop

- Interestingly, the very paper by Skogan (1984) that serves as *the* reference for *cost–benefit* perspective has already been touching on the *role of others*.
- I speculate that it did not catch on mainly because there was no such dimension in the widely used victimization surveys (Xie & Baumer, 2019):
  - In NCVS, a question about informing some party other than the police first appeared only in the latest update (Bureau of Justice Statistics, 2022), the transition to the new instrument happened in 2025, the data is yet to be published.
  - In CSEW such question is reserved for 10-15 year-olds only.
  - ICVS never featured such question.
- Enter RCVS, which has included a question about informing friends and family right from the start (2018).

Data

- I use pooled data from three waves of the Russian Crime Victimization Survey (RCVS) (Kuchakov et al., 2026) — a nationally representative survey targeting the entire adult (18+) population of Russia.
- The survey waves were carried out in 2018, 2021, and 2024 in the Russian language.
- All three survey waves employed a Random Digit Dialing (RDD) methodology — a probability sampling technique in which telephone numbers are generated at random. Data collection was conducted using the Computer-Assisted Telephone Interviewing (CATI) method.
- Raking algorithm was used to obtain weights for correction of sample imbalances.

Data

- All respondents are asked only about their most recent incident occurring within the five years.
- The type of an incident is derived from responses to a number of dichotomous questions presented in everyday language.
- After removing non-victims, victims of attempted cybercrime, and of offenses classified as 'other', my sample consists of 5,697 observations.
- The questionnaires employed across the three waves are nearly identical. An exception important for this study is the question about *emotional impact* of victimization — it was introduced only in the 2024 wave.

Data: Tabulation of reported cases share by principal variables

		Cybercrime		Fraud		Theft		Assault		Robbery	
		N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)
Totals											
Survey wave	2018	442	0.43 (0.04)	328	0.38 (0.04)	841	0.62 (0.03)	211	0.53 (0.05)	141	0.73 (0.06)
	2021	837	0.44 (0.02)	208	0.53 (0.05)	545	0.62 (0.03)	266	0.59 (0.04)	100	0.68 (0.06)
	2024	695	0.52 (0.02)	34	0.73 (0.11)	394	0.56 (0.03)	254	0.56 (0.04)	78	0.62 (0.07)
	Pooled	1974	0.47 (0.02)	570	0.45 (0.03)	1780	0.61 (0.02)	731	0.56 (0.02)	319	0.69 (0.04)
Post-victimization behavior											
Victim informed	No	305	0.36 (0.04)	58	0.31 (0.09)	118	0.42 (0.06)	129	0.2 (0.05)	42	0.46 (0.13)
friends or relatives	Yes	1669	0.49 (0.02)	512	0.47 (0.03)	1662	0.62 (0.02)	602	0.65 (0.03)	277	0.71 (0.04)
Victim went	No	1974	0.47 (0.02)	570	0.45 (0.03)	1780	0.61 (0.02)	385	0.41 (0.03)	187	0.64 (0.05)
to hospital	Yes	0	n/a	0	n/a	0	n/a	346	0.74 (0.03)	132	0.77 (0.05)
Incident characteristics											
Damage: money,	0 to 1	185	0.22 (0.04)	48	0.24 (0.09)	191	0.49 (0.05)	555	0.52 (0.03)	39	0.61 (0.11)
thnd rub.	1 to 10	702	0.31 (0.02)	118	0.26 (0.06)	423	0.45 (0.03)	67	0.59 (0.07)	62	0.61 (0.09)
	10 to 50	561	0.5 (0.03)	137	0.39 (0.06)	636	0.61 (0.03)	46	0.7 (0.09)	116	0.66 (0.06)
	50+	526	0.7 (0.03)	267	0.65 (0.04)	530	0.76 (0.03)	63	0.85 (0.06)	102	0.78 (0.06)
Damage: physical	No	0	n/a	0	n/a	0	n/a	175	0.44 (0.05)	53	0.6 (0.09)
	Light	0	n/a	0	n/a	0	n/a	246	0.5 (0.04)	83	0.69 (0.08)
	Heavy	0	n/a	0	n/a	0	n/a	134	0.74 (0.05)	58	0.67 (0.08)
Damage: emotional	Light	129	0.33 (0.05)	4	0.75 (0.34)	75	0.47 (0.07)	56	0.37 (0.08)	4	0.75 (0.39)
(wave 2024 only)	Medium	167	0.48 (0.05)	6	0.05 (0.17)	109	0.61 (0.06)	55	0.46 (0.08)	22	0.44 (0.12)
	Heavy	393	0.58 (0.03)	24	0.96 (0.05)	206	0.56 (0.04)	143	0.67 (0.05)	52	0.67 (0.08)

Proportions of reported victimizations and standard errors were calculated using observations' weights to correct for sample imbalances.

Methods: Framework

Individual-level: decision making model developed in *After the Crime* by Greenberg and Ruback (1992):

- a victim is stressed, their assumptions about the world challenged,
- they may need help to
  - label the incident as crime,
  - assess its seriousness,
  - think through response options;
- others' influence takes form of
  - cuing the victim to particular options and scripts not yet considered,
  - providing information,
  - channeling certain norms,
  - offering emotional and practical support.

Methods: Framework

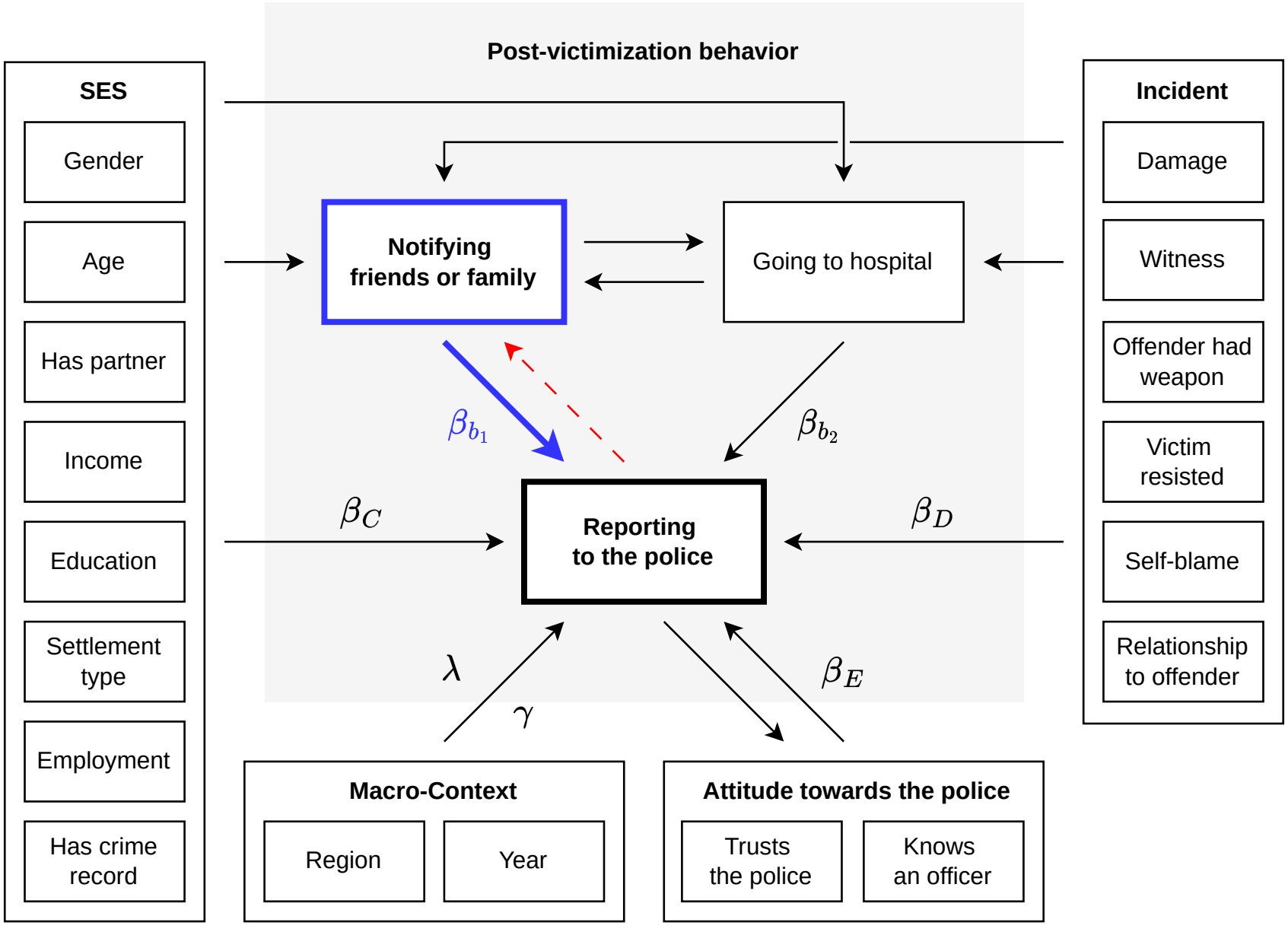
Network-level: help-seeking as a social process, in the spirit of Pescosolido (1992):

- social phenomena occurs in interaction, rather than in isolated cost–benefit driven decisions,
- we should focus on these interactions, i.e. on the paths people take in seeking help,
- response, such as reporting to the police, emerge on these paths,
- the principal question, then, is what defines these paths.

I aim to make case for this perspective by

- showing how social network activation affects path (probability of passing through the police station),
- exploring predictors of social network activation.

Methods: Model



Methods: Model

My base model has the following linear form:

$$Reported_i = \beta_{b_1} ToldSomeone_i + \beta_{b_2} WentHospital_i + \sum \beta_C SES_i + \sum \beta_D Incident_i + \sum \beta_E Attitude_i + \lambda_i + \gamma_i + \epsilon_i$$

where

- *Reported* is a binary indicator of informing the police,
- *ToldSomeone* indicates if a victim talked with friends or family about the incident,
- *WentHospital* indicates seeking medical help,
- *SES* comprises variables related to socioeconomic status,
- *Incident* stands for incident characteristics,
- *Attitude* is a vector of variables that capture a victim's attitude towards the police,
- λ and γ are region and survey year fixed effects.

Methods: Model

I estimate the model using logistic regression. Since post-victimization behavior is known to vary with crime type (Greenberg & Ruback, 1992), I run separate regressions on six subsets of data split by crime type:

- theft,
- face-to-face fraud,
- cybercrime,
- assault,
- all property crime,
- all violent crime.

Property crime comprises theft, fraud, and cybercrime; violent crime includes assault and robbery (the latter being too rare to estimate a separate model).

Results 1: Odds ratios of reporting (abbr. regression table)

	Theft	Fraud	Cybercrime	Assault	All prop.	All viol.
Post-victimization behavior						
Victim informed friends or family	2.407***	1.769	1.898**	8.203***	2.121***	10.335***
Victim went to hospital				12.422***		10.743***
Incident characteristics						
Damage:						
Financial, thnd rub. (*ref. level*: 0 to 1):						
1 to 10	0.842	0.990	1.872*	2.086	1.189	1.835
10 to 50	1.929***	1.884	4.126***	3.107	2.561***	2.583***
50+	3.768***	7.830***	10.477***	4.241***	5.626***	2.954***
Physical (*ref. level*: No):						
Light				1.014		1.167
Heavy				1.453		0.897
There was a witness				1.749		1.196
Victim resisted				0.689		0.516
Offender had a weapon				2.024**		1.961
Self-blame	0.548***	0.822	0.511***	0.823	0.533***	0.565**
Victim-offender relationship (*ref. level*: Stranger):						
Acquaintance				1.186		0.914
Colleague or neighbor				6.790**		11.795*
Friend or relative				0.457		0.733
Spouse or partner				0.691		1.050
N	1752	518	1959	463	4308	628
McFaddens' R2	0.202	0.328	0.188	0.500	0.157	0.452

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. All models include controls for demographics variables and attitude proxies, as well as region and survey year FE. Standard errors are clustered by region and survey year. Observations' weights are used to correct sample imbalances.

Results 1: Robustness tests (odds ratios of reporting, abbr. regression tables)

	Theft	Fraud	Cybercrime	Assault	All prop.	All viol.
Panel A. Base model, pooled data of three survey waves						
Victim informed friends or family	2.407***	1.769	1.898**	8.203***	2.121***	10.335***
N	1752	518	1959	463	4308	628
McFaddens' R2	0.202	0.328	0.188	0.500	0.157	0.452
Panel B. Base model, wave 2024 only						
Victim informed friends or family	2.516		1.491	23.997***	1.598*	23.520**
N	328		665	186	1082	229
McFaddens' R2	0.266		0.199	0.623	0.171	0.613
Panel C. Base model augmented with emotional damage, wave 2024 only						
Victim informed friends or family	2.511		1.442	20.065**	1.552*	21.506**
Emotional damage (*ref. level*: Light):						
Medium	1.473		1.605	1.610	1.359	1.413
Heavy	1.515		1.811	0.745	1.735*	0.541
N	324		657	186	1072	229
McFaddens' R2	0.261		0.199	0.621	0.170	0.613
Panel D. Base model, pooled data, reported-but-no-case observations removed						
Victim informed friends or family	2.485***	1.289	1.304	16.080**	1.837	23.570***
N	1234	323	1478	281	3150	403
McFaddens' R2	0.254	0.419	0.251	0.625	0.206	0.556

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. All models include controls for demographics variables, incident features, and attitude proxies. FE are region and year in panel A and D, region only in panels B and C. Standard errors are clustered by region and year in panels A and D, by region only in panels B and C. Observations' weights are used to correct sample imbalances.

Results 2: Odds ratios of social network activation

	Theft	Fraud	Cybercrime	Assault	All prop.	All viol.
SOCIOECONOMIC STATUS						
Male	0.448***	0.227*	0.401***	0.436	0.476***	0.450
Age (*ref. level*: 35–49):						
18–24	0.679	1.019	1.479	0.299**	0.995	0.403*
25–34	0.554	2.112**	1.319	0.173***	0.899	0.232***
50–64	1.031	1.474	1.209	1.546	0.974	2.124
65+	0.637	0.777	1.152	0.943	0.788	1.639
Has a partner	2.185**	1.869	1.668*	1.133	1.716**	1.360
Middle to upper household income	1.512**	0.307**	1.3508	0.844	1.075	0.905
Small town or village	1.026	0.344	0.974	0.528	0.914	0.455**
Higher education	1.483*	4.684	0.998	0.814	1.196	0.836
Employed or student	0.957	1.227	1.806**	1.803	1.299	1.920
INCIDENT CHARACTERISTICS						
Self-blame	0.623	0.910	0.667*	1.220	0.589***	1.311
Victim-offender relationship (*ref. level*: Stranger):						
Acquaintance				0.091***		0.075***
Colleague or neighbor				1.730		1.595
Friend or relative				0.533		0.517
Spouse or partner				1.117		0.626
VICTIM'S ATTITUDE TOWARDS THE POLICE						
Has crime record	0.566	4.604	1.247	0.718	0.879	0.734
Knows an officer	1.067	5.667**	1.570**	0.501	1.415	0.755
N	1431	344	1895	416	4260	557
McFaddens' R2	0.218	0.363	0.129	0.361	0.133	0.379

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. All models include controls for going to hospital, damage level, victim resistance, weapon use, witness presence, as well as region and survey year FE. Standard errors are clustered by region and survey year. Observations' weights are used to correct sample imbalances.

Conclusion

Activation of social network does affect the path of help-seeking after criminal victimization:

- the effect is more pronounced in violent crime, where it is as large as that of visiting hospital,
- in property crimes modeling results are mixed:
  - theft: the effect is fairly stable,
  - face-to-face fraud: no effect,
  - cybercrime: evidence is tentative.

Conclusion

Turning to the intimate circle for help is strongly associated with demographics variables:

- being a male is a prominent negative predictor of informing friends or family about property victimization,
- younger victims are much less likely to discuss violent victimization with others,
- having a partner makes sharing more probable in cases of theft and cybercrime but not fraud,
- higher household income is positively associated with the probability of discussing theft, but negatively in case of fraud,
- living in a small town or village halves chances of relating a story about violent victimization.

Conclusion

Also, the character of victimization plays its role:

- cybercrime victimization seems to produce shame that precludes seeking help,
- violent victimization by an acquaintance is hard to share with the intimate circle.

Conclusion

These results warrant further exploration of post-victimization behavior from social interaction perspective:

- mapping paths people take in seeking help
- and studying factors of taking or of availability of these paths.

This will require updating our instruments:

- we need to record the order of events post-victimization,
- we are should be interested in the content of the interactions along the path.


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